

CHAPTER 1

Philadelphia Row House

A Paradise of Small Houses

On top of Philadelphia's City Hall stands an enormous bronze statue of William Penn, a visionary who set out to create a new type of city: a place where a diverse group of people would coalesce around a common set of ideals, and equality and health were embedded into its very design. From his perch five hundred feet in the air, Penn looks out over the city he founded over three hundred years ago. Yet past the glittering skyscrapers, lying before him is not quite the utopia he imagined but instead a vast plain of squat brick buildings: tens of thousands of narrow, brick row homes lined up side by side, constituting nearly 70 percent of the city's housing stock. They come in every conceivable style and configuration. In the old colonial core, tiny homes dating as far back as the eighteenth century, with dormered windows jutting out from the sloped roofs, line cobblestoned alleys. Near stately Rittenhouse Square, the row houses become opulent mansions clad in granite and brownstone. Radiating out from Center City, even more variations of the row house line the city's straight, gridded streets for miles in every direction.

The row house traces its roots to Northern Europe, but Philadelphia—considered to be the birthplace of America—adapted the structure into one uniquely suited to the United States. Their compact, single-family structure allowed for private property and individual expression despite the crowded

urban environment, thus giving even working families the opportunity to be homeowners. Local builders became experts at manipulating the city's narrow lots to create well-appointed and commodious homes. The Founding Fathers saw their columns, carefully ordered façades, and other neoclassical details as linking the nation to the ancient republics of Greece and Rome. As the Philadelphia row home was exported across the nation, it helped shape the country's very notion, both physically and symbolically, of what a house should be.



Utopian communities often bring to mind images of dusty people worshiping crystals in geodesic domes, or bearded hippies in hemp chokers living in huts rubbed down with elk manure. However, left out of this discussion is perhaps one of the most successful utopias ever conceived—Philadelphia. As the son of an admiral, William Penn had been groomed to be part of Britain's ruling elite from an early age. However, he lasted only two years at Oxford and shortly after had a religious awakening, renouncing his upbringing to join the radical Religious Society of Friends. His conversion to Quakerism made him a permanent outsider in Anglican England. He became notorious for his diatribes calling for more civil liberties and was arrested several times for instigating a riot. Yet despite this background, due to a debt owed to his father, in 1681 King Charles II of England granted Penn a charter for forty-five thousand square miles of land in the American colonies.¹

Penn had been indelibly shaped by the inequality of Europe, where the aristocracy luxuriated in gardens and palaces while the rest of the population lived in squalid conditions, especially in urban centers. Cities like London were a suffocating warren of densely packed, crudely built wooden structures enveloping narrow, chamber pot-soaked streets. These conditions had led to the Great Fire of London in 1666, when Penn was twenty-two years old. The city had been almost entirely destroyed, with the lead roof of St. Paul's Cathedral melting into molten rivulets that ran into the gutters. It was an event that both traumatized and radicalized him.

Penn saw his land grant not as a way to gain wealth, but as an opportunity to test out a holy experiment based on democratic and communal values.² The capital city of his colony would be a refutation of the European

city—a refuge for poor craftspeople, farmers, and religious minorities.³ Thomas Holme, a surveyor hired by Penn, chose a well-drained narrow strip of land on which to build the capital, bound by the Delaware River to the east and the Schuylkill River to the west. Penn entered into a purchase agreement with the Lenape people, who had inhabited this area along the Delaware for centuries, reserving the land they lived on for their use.* However, Penn’s view of equality did not extend to African Americans, with slavery existing in the city until the nineteenth century.

On this space between the two rivers, Holme plotted a grid of numbered streets running north to south along the Delaware, bisected by two main streets: Broad, running north to south, and Market, running east to west. In each quadrant of the city, Holme placed large public squares, with the largest one in the center.⁴ Penn wanted his capital to be more like an agglomeration of country estates than like the crowded and congested urban centers he knew back home. He instructed Holme to lay out the city so that each house could have “ground on each side for gardens, or orchards, or field, that it may be a green country town, that will always be wholesome and never burn.”⁵ Instead of buildings being jammed so close that it was unclear where one ended and another began, the city’s large blocks were divided into half-acre lots, over four times the size of the standard single-family home lot found in most American cities today.

This type of utilitarian street grid, with single-family homes nestled into large lots, has become the basic template of US urban development. It is a scheme that dates back to the Bronze Age and has been found in places ranging from the Indus Valley to Mexico. However, at the time that Philadelphia was being planned, it had fallen out of fashion, and Penn’s decision to lay out the city in this way reflected his utopian vision. During the same period in which English architect Christopher Wren was

proposing to replace London's medieval warren of streets—now ravaged by the Great Fire—with radial streets that framed palaces, public spaces, and grand monuments, Penn's grid was meant to avoid these hierarchies and make all places in the city more or less equal. He hoped this would promote equality and a common understanding among the city's residents. The radical and visionary plan for Philadelphia became a powerful marketing tool for the new city. It was advertised across England, inspiring colonists to journey across the ocean to Penn's capital, Philadelphia—the City of Brotherly Love.

While Penn envisioned Philadelphia as an egalitarian utopia, the site that Thomas Holme had selected along two large rivers was ideal for commerce. The city soon became one of the most important colonial ports, where a robust community of merchants traded with Europe, the Southern colonies, and the Caribbean. Just eight years after its founding in 1682, Philadelphia's twenty-two shopkeepers and 119 craftspeople were considered to be the most skilled in all the American colonies.⁶ Yet Penn was never truly able to see his city blossom due to being called back to England to join the court of King James II.⁷ In total he only spent four years in Philadelphia, and without his tight grip, the inhabitants of the thriving colonial port ran roughshod over his dream of a country town.



Penn's visionary plan was out of step with a basic reality of the time. In the seventeenth century, the main mode of transportation was one's own body. Philadelphia was therefore, like all other pre-nineteenth-century settlements, a walking city. Development did not sprawl across the grid in large estates, which would have necessitated long, arduous trips in order to accomplish everyday tasks. Instead, homes and businesses clustered into just a few blocks around the Delaware River wharfs. By 1689, the forty-three half-acre lots Holme had plotted along the Delaware had been subdivided into seventy much smaller parcels. Alleys were cut through the large blocks, with the single half-acre lot along each being subdivided into as many as twenty additional parcels. By the first decade of the nineteenth century, over ten alleys had been cut from Front Street to Second Street.⁸

One of these alleys had been created in 1703 when two blacksmiths named Arthur Wells and John Gilbert opened a cart path through their

adjoining properties. The 15-foot-wide Elfreth's Alley, as it became known, quickly filled with diminutive wooden 800-square-foot stand-alone homes packed side by side. The interiors of these houses utilized medieval floor plans that colonists brought with them from England. They consisted of a *hall*—a more public room that faced the street and was the setting for daily chores like cooking and making soap and yarn—and a slightly smaller back *parlor*, which was a more private, formal space for resting or entertaining guests. While larger homes would have additional rooms on the upper floors, the tiniest of these homes were called *huts* and had sleeping areas lofted above the parlor, accessed by a ladder.

Along narrow lanes like Elfreth's, all classes and social strata huddled together. Wealthy merchants and doctors lived next door to town criers and skinners. The economy at the time revolved around small family-sized firms, and each tiny home would often double as a place of business. The front hall would become a storefront, a workshop for an artisan, or an office for a businessperson. Even the wealthiest merchants lived above their counting houses next to the docks on Water Street.⁹ The mixed nature of the city made it a lively environment. Merchants would place their wares on display outdoors and people would mingle in the street. Over one hundred taverns operated in the city, which facilitated communication, business, and the city's social life, with beer being sometimes used as currency.¹⁰

However, life in colonial Philadelphia was not an endless spring break flotilla party. The city's compactness made it susceptible to the disease and fire that Penn had so desperately wanted to avoid. Trash and animal manure piled up along the narrow alleys, and when fires occurred it was common for neighbors to form human chains to pass water buckets to put them out. Yet the city was also incredibly dynamic. Penn's views about equality and religious freedom had imbued the city with a culture of entrepreneurial innovation where ideas were freely exchanged. Philadelphia became one of the main intellectual centers of the colonies, and in places like City Tavern, which stood a block from the river, public debates and lectures helped foment and hasten the American Revolution.



Penn had envisioned Philadelphia as a city of the future, yet in the late seventeenth century, its architecture was essentially medieval. The wood

shacks that composed the city's housing, with their hall-and-parlor floor plans, epitomized the centuries-old practices that had been brought to the colonies directly from Europe. Building materials were culled from local sources, such as timber, thatch, and clay, and the resulting structures often blended in with the natural landscape. These dwellings embodied *vernacular architecture*, which the professor and folklorist Henry Glassie defines as buildings that exhibit "the knowledge that people develop during lives of environmental engagement."¹¹

However, a movement that sought alternatives to these age-old practices had been percolating in Europe since the Italian Renaissance of the fifteenth century. Inspired by the texts and ruins left behind by ancient Rome and Greece, cities like Florence and Venice became showcases for an architecture that gave aesthetic principles the same importance as environmental ones. Instead of façades that were primarily intended to protect the inhabitants from intruders or weather, they were carefully arranged based on proportion and symmetry. Decorative bands divided each floor of the building, and a cornice was placed at the roofline. Elaborate ornamentation, including Greek and Roman columns, was used to delineate windows and doors. On a vernacular building, a person with knowledge of the local environment and culture could intuit the practical purpose of each structural element. However, to even begin to understand these Renaissance buildings, one needed a more esoteric and privileged knowledge of classical architecture.

By the seventeenth century, the Renaissance architecture of Italy had made its way to England. On the outskirts of British cities, parks or squares inspired by Italian piazzas were constructed. Around these, designers envisioned grand palaces with unified, classical design schemes. However, the nobility—perhaps with the feces-soaked petri dishes that had constituted most British cities still fresh in their minds—largely preferred estates in the country.¹² And so a new type of residential architecture started to rise along these squares: the terrace house.

This type of narrow house—divided from its neighbors on either side by a shared party wall—had long been popular in Belgium, the Netherlands, and other Northern European countries. It is believed that British aristocrats were exposed to this type of home when they fled to Holland after Puritans executed the king and took over the British government in

the mid-seventeenth century under Oliver Cromwell.¹³ The houses that began to appear in England around the new squares and public spaces had exteriors that were unified across multiple units into a single grand façade ornamented with cornices and long rows of columns. The entire structure was placed onto a podium, with a terrace in front of the colonnade. Instead of appearing as multiple dwellings, the overall effect of these monumental structures was of a palace.

These homes, which became known as *terrace houses*, proved to be extremely popular in Britain, and wealthy urbanites came to favor them over detached villas. By the eighteenth century, grand developments, such as the Royal Crescent in Bath, started to flank squares and public spaces across the country. During the Industrial Revolution, mass-production technologies allowed developers to build standardized terrace houses for the middle and working classes outside booming cities like Manchester, Liverpool, and Birmingham.¹⁴ The terrace house came to be the standard urban dwelling of the United Kingdom, with even the home of the prime minister at 10 Downing Street in London being a narrow, gray-brick structure.



The elegant terrace houses of England were contrasted by the feculent appearance of many American cities. Upon one of his first visits back to Philadelphia after returning to England, William Penn was disgusted by the pigs proudly trotting down the mud-logged streets and the bedraggled collection of homes that included log cabins and caves dug out of the riverbank. In response, Penn ordered a brick factory be constructed, and thanks to the region's amenable soils, by 1690 the city boasted four brickmakers and ten bricklayers.¹⁵

As the leading port and intellectual center of the American colonies, Philadelphia received and absorbed the architectural ideas coming out of England. One of the first structures in the city to demonstrate the classical design of Europe was the Slate Roof House, built just north of City Tavern in 1687 by a Quaker merchant named Samuel Carpenter. This home was not made from wood, nor did it have the steeply pitched roof or overhanging second-floor “pents” associated with the medieval style—instead, it had a flat façade made of brick produced by one of the

city's factories. Its tall chimneys, dormered roof, and windows and doors were carefully arranged in the Georgian style, a more refined version of Renaissance architecture that had emerged in England. With its attention to proportions such as the height of each room and the spacing of the windows, the Georgian style proved ideal not just for grand palaces but also for much smaller buildings.¹⁶ In 1691, a ten-home complex built at Front and Dock Streets took the features of the Slate Roof House and distilled them into an economically and spatially efficient form.¹⁷ This complex, called Budd's Long Row, was the first terrace house development to be built in the United States.

Row houses, as they became known in the US, quickly took hold in Philadelphia and were soon occupied by every class and social strata in the city. Along the wide main arteries like Market Street, traders and merchants built large row homes to show off their wealth and refinement. These homes, which still stand in some parts of the city, rise to three stories and, like the Slate Roof House, have a dormered roof and tall chimneys. Their façades are made from pressed brick, which have very small seams, making them look like one solid piece of stone. They are further adorned with neoclassical detailing—decorative cornices, windows shutters, and elaborate door frames, all of which vary depending on the social status of the owner. The layout of these large row homes modified the traditional hall-and-parlor scheme by applying the Georgian principles of formality and privacy. The two rooms, which were previously of different sizes, now had the same dimensions. In larger homes, instead of entering the front room directly, one would first enter a hallway running along the party wall with the entrance to the ground-floor rooms leading off it. This was almost identical to the upper-class terrace houses of England and became known as the *London house plan* (see image 4).¹⁸

Though imposing, these large row homes were still confined to skinny lots, constrained by the spatial limitations of the walking city. Visitors to Philadelphia, especially from the Southern colonies, would comment on the lack of space. By the early nineteenth century, kitchens became a way to both enlarge and distinguish row homes. Using the long lots, kitchens would be contained in a narrow structure appended to the back of the house called an *el*. For the wealthiest families, the *el* would also have a dining room and a second floor containing servants' quarters (see image 3).

On lesser streets, middle-class artisans and merchants would occupy two-story row homes with a dormered roof that sheltered a small attic room called a *garret*, containing rooms for children or servants. The neoclassical detailing would often be reduced to a simple cornice and arched doorway. For the more well-off, the kitchen would be contained in a small el, but in most houses, it would be in the basement and accessed from an outside hatch that allowed people to bring coal, firewood, and other messy items inside without having to walk them through their main living space. The shutter doors leading to these basements are still a prominent feature along Elfreth's Alley and in other older sections of the city.

The interiors of these more modest homes had the two-room Georgian plan, but because they were on narrower lots, they lacked a hallway. The front parlor acted as a living room and the back room as a formal dining area. In some cases, the wall dividing the rooms featured a large French door that could be opened in order to combine them into one large space for entertaining. Instead of the standard flight of stairs, the upper stories were accessed by an incredibly compact spiral stairwell, often so narrow and steep that a handle, similar to one that would be used to open a cupboard, was attached to the wall to help people climb them. The style of these staircases diverged from those found in England or Europe and, along with the kitchen el, are one of the true innovations of the Philadelphia row house: their compact nature maximizes the building's vertical space while leaving enough room for a decently sized living area.

The lowest class of housing was found along the narrow alleys and the small dead-end passages, called courts, that went into the interiors of the city blocks. Here, a slender type of row house predominated, one that rose to three stories in height with only one 10-by-12-foot room on each floor. These homes were nicknamed "father, son, and holy ghost," which was shortened to trinity—the name they are commonly known by today. Trinities became home to the city's poorest residents, who were often mariners, low-level artisans, and laborers, with each of the small rooms sometimes rented out to a different family. Many of these residents would bring their own mattress to avoid sleeping on the floor and becoming a buffet for the infamous vermin known to inhabit many of these court homes. However, these accommodations were still better than those of the most destitute, who slept under the tables at grog shops and oyster houses.



The home of Philadelphia’s most famous citizen, Benjamin Franklin, illustrates the development of row homes in the city. In the mid-eighteenth century, Franklin left his rented house in the crowded walking city and built a detached single-family home nestled into a garden on the edge of town. As Franklin grew more prominent, he added a new wing with a dining room and library, and three large Georgian row homes used as rental properties were built along Market Street at the front of the property. By the time of Franklin’s death in 1790, the city had enveloped his estate. His heirs cut a small court named Orianna Street through the property, demolished his large house, and built in its place speculative row homes that served as rental units for the general public.¹⁹

By the time of the American Revolution, Philadelphia had become the largest city in the colonies and the fourth-largest in the English-speaking world. What once was a crude settlement of rural shacks had been transformed into an elegant city of brick row homes. The once-muddy streets were paved with flagstone sidewalks with posts to protect pedestrians from traffic. Not everyone embraced the Philadelphia style—foreigners found the city’s straight streets and uniform buildings odd, with one diplomat saying it was too much like a chessboard to be beautiful.²⁰

But the young nation took pride in Philadelphia’s orderly appearance. During meetings of the Continental Congress, Thomas Jefferson slept and worked in a row home along Market Street. He saw the city’s classical architecture as connecting the country to a lineage stretching back to the democracies of ancient Greece and Rome. After the Revolution, the English Georgian style became known in America as the Federal style. This patriotic architecture was most visible in the brick-fronted, dormered-roof row houses, which came to dominate the cities of the Northeast in the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries.²¹ The gridded streets and identical houses were thought to convey the nation’s values of equality, property ownership, and the common good. Penn’s vision had seemingly been realized. However, the true nature of Philadelphia’s urban environment was often hidden along alleys and courts. Just behind the stately homes on the main boulevards lurked the rickety wood huts and trinities that housed over two-thirds of the population.²²



As Philadelphia grew, the construction of row houses became one of the city's main economic drivers. Between 1790 and 1850 alone, over fifty-two thousand homes were built.²³ However, the nation's first architecture school would not be founded until 1868, at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology. Moreover, the title of *architect* was only used by a select few self-taught elites whose practice consisted almost entirely of grand civic buildings and large mansions. Housing remained almost entirely the realm of builders with no formal education. Their training consisted only of a teenage apprenticeship followed by a few years spent as journeymen, wandering the colonies providing day labor for various craftspeople. Yet despite this, the builders of Philadelphia developed innovations such as the kitchen el and the tiny spiral staircases. They became masters in manipulating the tight confines of narrow lots and party walls to create light-filled and well-proportioned homes. With their tall ceilings and windows on multiple sides of rooms, even the tiny trinities still feel spacious today.

The city's tight-knit building culture resulted in design approaches being shared and replicated, and a remarkable uniformity exists across the row homes built during the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries. Entire blocks have similar cornices, window treatments, and rooflines, even when built at different times by different builders. This consistency was further facilitated by the use of pattern books, which acted as how-to manuals and contained everything from architectural styles and floor plans to technical specifications. Indeed, the rise of classical design during the Renaissance is credited to a pattern book called *Ten Books on Architecture*. This ancient text, written by a Roman architect and engineer named Vitruvius, was rescued from the dusty shelf of a Swiss monastery by a Florentine papal aide in 1414.²⁴

The most commonly used pattern books in the United States were often less illustrious—one of the most popular for US row houses in the early nineteenth century was a British publication called *Mechanick Exercises*. Although the title makes it seem as if it was written by a child learning to read and write, it was published by Joseph Moxon and purported to be able to teach someone to build a house without any experience as a journeyman or apprentice.²⁵ British pattern books like Moxon's led to the proliferation

of the row house in Philadelphia and then across the US. This resulted in common features across the homes, such as the widespread utilization of the London house plan layout and Georgian design schemes.

The Philadelphia row house became so admired that the city's builders spread it up and down the East Coast. As this occurred, the standardized elements of the row house were tempered to different cultural and geographic constraints. By the mid-nineteenth century, unique variations of the row home could be found across the country, designed for local preferences and using local materials. In Baltimore, marble quarried just north of the city adorned elegant Italianate façades with brilliant white stoops, windowsills, and decorative friezes popping out of deep-red brick exteriors. In Washington, DC, row homes were set back from the street with a small garden in front and a bay window capped with a small turret. The stark difference between row homes in Baltimore and Washington, just forty miles apart, demonstrates the hyperlocal building cultures that emerged during this time.

In 1810, an American architect named Robert Mills attempted to wrest control of the row house from the builder and elevate it to high design. Mills was from Charleston, South Carolina, and moved to Philadelphia after having trained under Thomas Jefferson and Benjamin Henry Latrobe, designer of the US Capitol. Up to this point, the vast majority of row house developments in the city had not advanced much since Budd's Long Row and merely repeated the same identical façade on each home. In a project called Franklin Row, Mills integrated the fronts of ten row houses into a grand and unified design. The basic elements of the Philadelphia row house—the arched doorway, chimney, and dormered roof—were refined by creating a pattern on the brick façade and using tripartite windows that framed one large window with two smaller ones.²⁶ Instead of being identical, the façades of each house varied slightly from the others to create a cohesive design.

However, such ambitious row house architecture would not be common for many more decades. The egalitarian values of the United States in the postcolonial period mandated that homes be relatively subdued and that grand architectural gestures be reserved for large civic buildings. Mills would go on to design the Washington Monument and the Treasury Building in Washington, DC, creating few other residential buildings.

Even after architecture emerged as a profession in the US, for decades its practitioners looked down on common housing, seeing it as the realm of “ignorant mechanics.”²⁷ Yet that Mills would even attempt a project like Franklin Row shows how deeply ingrained the row home had become in the building culture of Philadelphia by the early nineteenth century.



In the years after the American Revolution, Philadelphia was such a powerful center that in 1808 Congress considered moving the capital back there from Washington, DC, a proposal that was only defeated after several days of vigorous debate.²⁸ Yet as trade became more important in the nineteenth century, Philadelphia’s inland river port, which often froze during the winter, was becoming outmoded compared to the deep open-water harbors of Baltimore and New York. Philadelphia’s civic leaders, faced with the prospect of becoming a backwater, lobbied the state legislature to invest in vital infrastructure that would bring the city into the industrial age: canals, railroads, and dams. These investments vaulted Philadelphia into one of the leading industrial centers in the nation, nicknamed “the workshop of the world.”

The life of a local artisan named Matthias Baldwin parallels the city’s rise as an industrial metropolis. Born in 1795, at age sixteen Baldwin apprenticed as a jeweler, later becoming a master with a small workshop on an alley off Walnut Street.²⁹ By the time of Baldwin’s death in 1866, this workshop had grown into the Baldwin Locomotive Works, with a plan that comprised over thirty buildings on nineteen acres of land. This was evidence of how far the city’s economy had advanced, from small artisans crafting twisted pipes and warped leather boots to firms creating some of the most cutting-edge technology of the time.

Due to its sheer size, the Baldwin Locomotive Works was not located in the city proper of Philadelphia but in what was then a separate jurisdiction called Spring Garden, northwest of Penn’s grid. The building industry in the city had previously consisted of small teams of builders constructing one to two homes a year, but with the new factories like the Locomotive Works came a need for much larger developments. This was aided by infrastructure improvements such as the omnibus, introduced in New York, Boston, and Philadelphia in the 1830s. These horse-drawn

carriages ran on fixed routes and transported workers from the periphery into the central city. The era of the walking city was over—development now spilled out from Philadelphia’s confines along the Delaware River to envelop the green fields surrounding it.

In 1849, a developer named Joseph Montgomery built thirty-two row houses right next to the Baldwin factory. Teams of subcontractors used an assembly-line approach: they first erected all of the party walls separating each row home from another, then all of the chimneys, then scaffolding for the roofs, and finally the interiors. Previously, smaller components such as window sashes, shutters, and doorways had to be fabricated by the builders themselves, usually during the winter, with the actual houses built during warmer months. But by the time Montgomery started work, these components were mass-produced in factories.³⁰

Although these new neighborhoods of the nineteenth century were built on virgin land outside Penn’s grid, they still mimicked the old fabric of the walking city. Penn had mandated that implementation of a standardized network of roads take precedent over private property. This resulted in the continuation of the original street grid as the city expanded.³¹ Montgomery’s development consisted of homes in a range of sizes, and following the precedent established in the old colonial city, he placed the larger, more well-appointed homes measuring 15 feet wide and 28 feet deep on the broad main streets.³² These homes eschewed the classical detail of the Federal-style houses—instead, they had plain brick façades, white cornices, and arched doorways and were meant for merchants and businesspeople who would ride the omnibus into the central city for work.

On a narrow alley directly behind the large merchant houses, Montgomery built much smaller, one-room-per-floor trinities whose only ornaments consisted of austere cornices and simple rectangular window frames. These homes were meant for working-class residents who could not afford the twelve-cent fare to ride on the omnibus and so needed to be within walking distance of their place of employment. Such workers included domestics who served in the development’s larger homes as well as employees of the Baldwin factory. These examples from Montgomery’s development show the continued tradition of placing different sizes of homes along roads according to their width as Philadelphia expanded beyond the walking city.

In cities like New York and Boston, the omnibus caused the rich to retreat to separate enclaves while the poor clustered in teeming slums. But in Philadelphia, because of the variety of housing types that were included in the city's new developments, the mixed-income nature of the walking city remained. Even today, tiny trinities sit directly across from new luxury high-rise apartments in Center City. This type of mixing was considered acceptable because in Philadelphia the social status of an area was not tied to the neighborhood, or even the block, but to the outermost homes lining a particular street. (This was also a concept that had been brought to the city from England, where it had become common for small apartments for servants, called *mews*, to be constructed over the stables behind the large terrace houses that were the public face of the area.) This quirk meant that wealthy residents in Philadelphia would remain in the heart of the city even as it industrialized. Around Rittenhouse Square, for instance, the elite built monumental row houses constructed of sandstone, granite, and marble with beautiful gardens filled with grapevines, roses, and honeysuckles. During this time, Philadelphia had one of the most established upper-class societies in the country, with a block of row houses on Chestnut Street considered the peak of the American aristocracy. However, directly behind the neighborhood's large stately homes were tiny trinities, which housed the linen weavers who worked in the nearby factories along the Schuylkill River (see image 3).³³

Montgomery's development and the other new neighborhoods growing around the factories outside the old walking city quickly became self-contained ecosystems with churches, schools, and business districts. With a large percentage of the population now commuting to factories or offices, by the mid-nineteenth century it was no longer common for homes to double as workshops and stores as they had during colonial times. However, developers retained some of these qualities by creating small retail spaces on the corners of blocks to house businesses serving the immediate neighborhood, like taverns, grocers, and—particularly during the twentieth-century Great Migration—storefront churches. These corner stores resulted in Philadelphia having a peculiar retail layout to this day. Instead of stores and restaurants only being clustered along one main drag, they remain scattered throughout otherwise entirely residential neighborhoods.³⁴ On the main streets it became common for

the bottom floors of row homes to be converted into small workshops and storefronts. Just as in the walking city, the proprietor would often live directly above.



With the row homes pressed closely to the sidewalk, Philadelphia's streets and alleys became much more than places to simply drive or walk down. As late as the 1950s, merchants would ply their wares and services door to door along alleyways and residential streets, including knife sharpening, kosher shochtim butchering live chickens, and horse-drawn aquariums where one could buy fresh fish. Some families would collect the manure from the horses that pulled these mobile storefronts to fertilize their gardens. Each block and neighborhood developed unique street games like half-ball and buck buck, relying on landmarks such as mailboxes, fire hydrants, or the front steps of a row house.

The city's vibrant street culture endures to this day. During the warm summer months, Philadelphians set up chairs, patio furniture, barbecues, and smokers directly along the sidewalk. Children scoop water from buckets and run through sprinklers underneath beach umbrellas set up in front of schools and daycares. In contemporary South Philadelphia sits a tiny court called Beck Street. If one notices it at all, it might simply be mistaken for a service alley, as it is full of garbage cans for the caf  s and shops along South 2nd Street. However, as you walk through the narrow passage, you notice that the street has been closed off with posts. Lights have been strung from house to house, illuminating a shared little piazza that the residents have filled with tables, chairs, and plants. Brooms and other household items are left leaning against the small homes. Compared to the large houses that make up most of America, Philadelphia's row homes and trinities are tiny. Yet their small spaces force people out of their homes and into the public realm. Through this, people become not just neighbors but also part of deeply rooted communities.



In 1854, the city of Philadelphia, which was still composed entirely of Holme's original grid, merged with Spring Garden and the broader county, growing the city to a total area of nearly 130 square miles. Compared to

the small urban scale of the colonial period, the new city borders were difficult to comprehend and were criticized for being ridiculously expansive, encompassing fields, pastures, and entire towns that had developed miles from the city core.³⁵ Yet as pokey horse-drawn omnibuses were replaced by much faster electric streetcars as well as elevated trains, subways, and commuter rail lines, the rural land around Philadelphia—and other large American cities—rapidly filled in.

However, in a country that had fancied itself an agrarian nation of gentleman farmers, the phalanx of identical row homes that marched like a Napoleonic army across the countryside beyond large industrial cities was seen as a particularly egregious type of blight. The marble friezes below the cornice of a Baltimore row house were lost on a European critic who only saw an “exceedingly unattractive” city where every building looked the same.³⁶ To a writer for the *Washington Post*, the richly carved facades of brownstone row homes in Brooklyn were not romantic or naturalistic but “pretentious, mere shells.”³⁷ Philadelphia had gone from being handsome, but exceedingly regular, to just being “droll and tepid,” as described by essayist Agnes Repplier.³⁸

To these critics, the row house was not charming or quaint but a manifestation of greed: a product of rapacious developers gobbling up land and erasing any contours of the landscape under a relentless grid of streets. This antipathy against speculative urban housing had deep historical roots. The inventor of the two-room London house plan that had become so popular in the US was a British developer named Nicholas Barbon. Described by one of his contemporaries, the lawyer and biographer Roger North, as an “exquisite mob master,” Barbon was infamous for defying laws and even royal decrees so that he could build his developments in the aftermath of the Great Fire of London. He illegally knocked down buildings and engaged in physical altercations with those who objected to his projects, including a group of lawyers who were angry that their view of the countryside was being destroyed.³⁹

The terrace houses that Barbon and other British developers produced were further criticized for being shoddy and cheap. Property developer George Downing saw his work merely as a path to wealth and power, and to achieve this he built the most inexpensive product possible. His development along Downing Street in London had mortar lines drawn onto

the façades of each home to give the appearance of evenly spaced bricks. British prime minister Winston Churchill said that the terrace house at 10 Downing Street and its neighbors were “shaky and lightly built by the profiteering contractor whose name they bear.”⁴⁰

Yet although the row house had been shrouded in ignominy virtually since its inception, these narrow houses represented something extraordinary both for the time and today. It was a modest but well-appointed home that even a working-class laborer could afford. The access provided by Philadelphia’s 264-mile transit network of horse-drawn streetcars and commuter trains, which by 1880 was the largest in the world, made constructing row houses relatively cheap. A developer could buy five acres located within a half hour of City Hall for as low as \$70,000 (the equivalent of a little more than \$2 million in 2023), where they would then erect nearly two hundred homes.⁴¹

While American cities at the turn of the twentieth century were marked by intractable urban slums, Baltimore and Philadelphia, due to their abundance of relatively cheap row houses, had the lowest rates of overcrowding in the country. Philadelphia in particular became an international model for housing and was nicknamed the “city of homes.” One of its typical row houses was even exhibited as a model dwelling in the famous White City of the 1893 World’s Columbian Exposition in Chicago. New York housing reformers Lawrence Veiller and Jacob Riis praised Philadelphia as a city “where the tenement problem was practically unknown,” and a writer for *Harper’s Magazine* described it as a “paradise of small houses.”⁴²

The housing successes of Philadelphia and Baltimore were due not only to an abundance of land and ambitious row house developers but also to unique financial innovations. Ground rent, a practice originally created in the seventeenth century to allow noblemen to develop their land without selling it, was widely utilized in Philadelphia and Baltimore and helped spur the development of row houses. Wealthy property owners, many of whom traced their holdings to land grants from William Penn, would advance money to builders who would develop homes on their property. These builders would then sell the homes directly to consumers or back to the landowner, who would then lease them out. In Philadelphia, row home owners would pay a ground rent—around 6 percent of the total cost of the land—as an annual fee. This system made it cost effective for

builders as well as consumers, who were able to purchase just the home and not the land underneath.

The affordability allowed by ground rents was further bolstered by the creation of a new type of lending institution. Sitting at 12th and Market in downtown Philadelphia is a five-hundred-foot-tall skyscraper composed of limestone piers framing large windows and topped by a large sign reading PSFS. Although this building, completed in 1932, is considered the first modernist skyscraper in the US, the firm that commissioned it, the Philadelphia Savings Fund Society, dates back considerably further. The Society was founded in 1816 as the nation's very first savings and loan. By the 1870s savings and loans had been established across the nation; however, Philadelphia, with over four hundred, had by far the most.⁴³ These institutions allowed working-class people to pool their funds then get a home mortgage at a modest interest rate. Anyone earning up to \$25 in a week was considered a potential homeowner.⁴⁴ During the turn of the twentieth century, wages maxed out at \$12 a week in a place like the Baldwin Locomotive Works, and, on the lower end, were \$7 for someone working in a textile factory. However, if a family had multiple earners, it was possible to purchase a 16-by-31-foot two-story brick row house for \$300 down.

By 1930, over half of the populations of Philadelphia and Baltimore owned their homes. However, this pathway into the middle class was not open to everyone. Since Philadelphia's founding, its neighborhoods had been not just economically diverse, with trinities sitting next to mansions, but also ethnically diverse. Various immigrants as well as a large population of African Americans lived together along the city's alleys and courts. However, as their white neighbors began to leave the crowded inner wards of the city for new homes in the early twentieth century, Black residents found themselves increasingly segregated into overcrowded and dilapidated areas of the city. Many savings and loans would not extend financing for African Americans who sought to live in newer and less crowded white areas. Although savings and loans did exist in Black neighborhoods, segregation meant there were fewer homes to choose from, and they were often more expensive than ones available to a white family.⁴⁵ In his sociological study of African Americans in Philadelphia in 1899, W. E. B. Du Bois wrote, "Here is a people receiving a little lower wages than usual for less desirable work and compelled in order to do that work to live in a little

less pleasant quarters than most people and pay for them somewhat higher rents.”⁴⁶ Denying an entire community the important wealth-building asset of homeownership would have lasting repercussions in Philadelphia and other American cities.



In 1879, a sixteen-year-old boy named Henry Ford walked the nine miles from his family’s farm to Detroit. Interested in mechanics from a young age, he longed to invent a device that would improve mobility for people living far from trains in small towns and rural farms. By 1903 he had founded the Ford Motor Company, one of hundreds of car manufacturers that had been established around that time in Detroit. The first model the company produced was a two-seater with an eight-horsepower engine. However, Ford, ever seeking to create a cheaper and more reliable car, released a new model every few months, each of which was assigned a different letter of the alphabet. On June 16, 1908, the Model T was introduced. It had a four-cylinder, twenty-horsepower engine, could go forty miles an hour, and was reliable and simple to fix. Whereas every other car of the time was over \$2,000, the Model T was \$850—well within reach of a working person—and the price would continue to decrease. By 1926, Ford produced nineteen thousand Model Ts a day, with other auto manufacturers producing tens of thousands of different types of vehicles.

The row home’s long and narrow shape had been premised on the fact that people needed to live close to their jobs and to transit. While these structures allowed people to attain ownership of a simple home in a crowded city, the trade-off was access to light. Because two sides of the building were party walls, windows could only be placed on the front and back of the building, a predicament that bedeviled all row houses from the tiny trinitities to large mansions. (In post–Civil War New York, as spacious light-filled apartments became in vogue, young residents would derisively refer to people still living in gloomy brownstones as “cave-dwellers.”⁴⁷)

Yet with the advent of widespread car ownership, people became freed of the spatial configurations that necessitated compact urban buildings like the row house. Detached single-family homes became accessible not just to gentlemen farmers but also to a clerk who could now drive downtown for work and be home for dinner. In contrast to row homes and apartments,

these structures had windows on all four sides and looked out onto a lawn instead of a concrete court with neighbors washing their unmentionables. By World War I, half a million people lived in the three suburban Pennsylvania counties surrounding the city.⁴⁸ The once-prodigious borders of Philadelphia now seemed like an overflowing girdle.

By the 1910s and '20s, urban developers were no longer competing to have the closest development to a streetcar but rather with single-family homes in the suburbs. In response, the row house went through yet another metamorphosis. These new homes were substantially larger than previous versions, being 20 feet wide and 36 feet deep. Instead of flat, highly urban façades, they had architectural styles associated with rustic and rural settings. Brick was replaced with stucco and topped with a mansard roof made from Spanish-style tile or shingles in the style of an old English cottage. Instead of a stairway leading directly to the sidewalk, these homes had a large porch and were buffered from the street by a small lawn. Inside, the ancient hall-and-parlor layout had been brought up to modern standards, with separate rooms for dining and living, a bathroom, and bedrooms.

The broader width of the buildings and the configuration on the lot allowed developers to incorporate more windows, and they were marketed as “day lighters.” Vast quantities were built in far Northeast and West Philadelphia as well as in Baltimore and Washington, DC. As the automobile became increasingly popular, many day lighters became untethered from mass transit, which had been the traditional instigator of row house development dating back to the horse-drawn omnibus.

Yet the term *day lighter* was a very feeble attempt for the row house to compete with the suburbs. In this new era of single-family homes, advertising the fact that a row house had more windows would be today’s equivalent of motels with fading signs touting cable TV. Suburban developers trying to lure middle-class residents out of the city ran ads describing row homes as “tunnels.” In 1918, the city of Baltimore annexed a large area on the fringe of the city and stipulated that no row houses could be built there.⁴⁹ The row house, which was once celebrated as a patriotic symbol of the nation, began to be seen as a second-class dwelling and was abandoned by the very cities that had initially embraced them the most.



After World War II, the remaining row houses of Philadelphia's walking city sat derelict and forlorn, like broken antiques stuffed in the corner of a secondhand store. All around them were massive government-funded public works projects of postwar renewal: elevated freeways, modernist towers, and windswept parking lots. Many of the old nineteenth-century row houses looked as if they hadn't been touched since carriages rolled along cobblestone streets. Their once-elegant façades were crooked and deteriorated and many served as flophouses. Other still lacked heating or indoor plumbing and were abandoned. In the half century after World War II, cities across the country hemorrhaged population, with Philadelphia losing half a million people. To planners and city officials, the diminutive row houses and other forms of workers' housing were embarrassing relics of the past, standing in the way of modernization.

Yet to a small contingent of countercultural bohemians, the old houses of the urban core were much preferable to sterile apartment towers or suburban tract homes. The beret-topped hipsters and reefer-curious professionals of the 1950s saw these buildings as romantic vestiges of the past. In the core of Philadelphia—as well as in Brooklyn Heights in New York and Federal Hill in Baltimore—old row houses started to sport fresh coats of paint. In the windows, filthy lace curtains were replaced with the faces of well-fed children sporting voluminous bowl cuts. Old storefronts were converted into smoky cafés where Chianti was sipped from goblets to the sound of bongos and spoken word poetry. As dilapidated buildings were purchased by these affluent newcomers, the poorer residents who once occupied them were displaced. In the 1960s in Philadelphia's historically working-class and African American Seventh Ward, the Black population fell by 55 percent, while the white population grew by 67 percent. The oldest portion of the Ward near the Delaware River was later rebranded Society Hill. In 1964, a British sociologist coined the term *gentrification* to describe the nascent movement of educated professionals back into cities.

The back-to-the-city movement soon become a national phenomenon, stretching from New Orleans to San Francisco. The seeds planted by this movement and other urban revitalization efforts have turned Penn's original grid, now known as Center City Philadelphia, into one of the most desirable areas in the region. Nine out of the top ten most expensive

neighborhoods in Philadelphia are either inside Penn's original grid or directly adjacent to it.⁵⁰ Tiny trinities have been converted into luxury pieds-à-terre, some selling for as much as \$800,000. The lineage of narrow row homes has endowed Philadelphia with a human scale that is missing from the vast majority of North American cities. A key criterion cited by urban designers and planners to define a walkable and dynamic neighborhood is one where a new type of activity is happening every fifteen to twenty feet.⁵¹ This is almost the exact scale of the row house, and the narrow tree-lined streets of the city's inner neighborhoods are jam-packed with cafés, bars, bookstores, and shops.

The current desire among young urbanites to live in vibrant, walkable, centrally located areas like Center City Philadelphia has made row homes fashionable again. Part of the appeal is that they can easily be adapted to contemporary tastes. Traditionally, row houses were constructed by putting joists between two party walls, meaning that none of the internal walls are load-bearing. This enables the interiors to be reconfigured: multiroom Victorian-era floor plans are overhauled into airy lofts, while the back is made into a giant window facing a garden. Behind an exterior from the nineteenth century, the interior can be an open, high-tech space of white walls, black leather furniture, and steel appliances. The resurgence of the row house is yet another amazing chapter in the incredible evolution of these buildings.

Yet the recent infusion of wealth has not been evenly distributed. In 1970, Philadelphia was still very much the city of homes, with nearly three-quarters of residents considered middle class. Around a small pocket of poverty in the ancient areas around Center City, the vast sprawl of the outer streetcar neighborhoods was economically solid and stable. Today this has flipped, with the central neighborhoods of Philadelphia being the wealthiest and whitest and the periphery being the poorest, housing the bulk of the Black and Latin American populations.⁵² The row house no longer represents a middle-class ideal but is instead a symbol of inequality: one in Center City is incredibly expensive, while an almost identical version a few miles away in North or West Philadelphia sits abandoned. This is the legacy of racist policies that have denied generations of African American residents homeownership opportunities and starved their neighborhoods of investment.

The Philadelphia row house is emblematic of housing in America, at once a marker of the country's promise and of its gnawing challenges. The blocks of tidy row houses that sprawled across the cities of the Northeast in the early twentieth century epitomized a country where an immigrant laborer could become a homeowner and where rich and poor lived next to one another in roughly similar houses. Today, Philadelphia's glittering core and dilapidated periphery illustrate the nation's deep inequality and segregation, where access to opportunity is often based on the color of your skin. Contradictions that have become emblematic of housing in the United States.

* Walter Licht et al., "The Original People and Their Land: The Lenape, Pre-History to the 18th Century," West Philadelphia Collaborative History (n.d.), retrieved January 22, 2023, <https://collaborativehistory.gse.upenn.edu/stories/original-people-and-their-land-lenape-pre-history-18th-century>; the scholar Pekka Hämäläinen argues that Penn's relations with Indigenous people were not pure altruism but a pragmatic decision based on the geopolitical power among Native tribes during this era. Almost immediately after Penn's death, his heirs reneged on this agreement under the notorious walking treaty where 750,000 acres were taken from the Lenape.

CHAPTER 6

Boston Triple-Decker

The Zone of Emergence

With the spread of the bungalow between 1900 and 1920, families went from living in small, dark homes that often lacked indoor plumbing to living in spacious dwellings with modern amenities. However, with these Progressive Era floor plans also came a new Progressive Era city. Low-slung bungalows sprawled outside of urban cores on 5,000-square-foot lots. Instead of a stoop spilling out onto the street, there was a porch buffered by a front yard, paired with an even larger yard in the back. Instead of apartments or row homes, housing in the US ultimately came to be deeply associated with this model of low-density, detached, single-family houses. However, the new spacious and amenity-filled homes were not just limited to the bungalow.

In the nineteenth century, Boston was one of the most congested and overcrowded cities on earth, and its old colonial core rivaled Lower Manhattan in population density. Yet by the 1920s, a very different type of neighborhood had emerged in the streetcar suburbs outside the confines of the old city. Instead of brick tenements, these areas were filled with wood structures buffered by landscaping. These buildings were not single-family homes but three separate apartments stacked on top of each other on a narrow lot. Typically clad in wood siding, with protruding porches and bay windows, Boston's ubiquitous triple-deckers incorporated elements

associated with the bungalow into a multiunit structure. They were not only a dramatic step up from the living conditions in tenements and other working-class urban housing of the time; they also provided hundreds of thousands of immigrants with access to homeownership and therefore a leg up into the middle class.

The triple-decker was just one of many multifamily housing types to flourish in the early twentieth century, all with modern floor plans and ample air and light. Yet rather than seeing these buildings as a tremendous innovation in urban housing, much of the public instead viewed their stealth density as a threat to both the physical and social character of their neighborhoods. Almost as soon as these new forms of urban multifamily housing emerged, the vitriol that had greeted the tenement was directed toward them. This puritanical distrust of urban housing, combined with a new wave of anti-immigrant bias, resulted in policies that effectively banned triple-deckers and many other urban housing types across the nation.



For its first two centuries of existence, Boston essentially functioned as a medieval English village transported to North America. In 1630, a group of English Calvinists known as the Puritans founded the city on the Shawmut Peninsula. This hilly spit of land sticking out into what is now Boston Harbor was so tenuous that high tides submerged the narrow neck connecting it to the mainland, turning it into an island. However, the city's layout did not reflect these geographic constraints—or any overriding urban principles at all—but rather religious ones. Homes were arranged in concentric circles around a central meetinghouse used for public assemblies, schools, and religious services, with no resident being permitted to live more than one and a half mile away to ensure regular attendance.¹ As Boston grew over time, these idiosyncratic origins resulted in a street pattern resembling a tangled web, leading to a popular urban legend that they are based on old cow paths.²

Perhaps due to these conservative religious roots, Boston stubbornly clung to a village aesthetic in the eighteenth century while other US cities demonstrated a reflexive ambition to become a great metropolis. Whereas brick dominated in the large Northeast cities south of the Connecticut River, wood remained a popular building material in New England.³ This meant that instead of adopting the more modern neoclassical architecture

coming out of Europe, Boston relied on vernacular rural housing types well into the eighteenth century. The Paul Revere House, in the city's North End, with its leaded-glass windows, steep pitched roof, and second floor suspended over the sidewalk, is the last remnant of this era still standing in central Boston.

As Philadelphia and New York filled with Federalist row houses along gridded streets, Boston was defined by wooden houses set back into gardens. An account of the city from the end of the eighteenth century described it as having an “advantage above most of the large towns on the continent with respect to garden spots. Few houses are without them, in which vegetables and flowers are raised, in some fruit trees are planted; and what is still more intrinsically good and valuable, the inhabitant is supplied with pure wholesome water from a well in his own yard.”⁴

In 1793, Charles Bulfinch—one of the most distinguished architects in the country and builder of many Boston landmarks, including the Massachusetts State House and Faneuil Hall—attempted to bring denser and more urbane forms of housing to the city. Like the grand terrace houses of England, his ambitious project, named Tontine Crescent, consisted of sixteen row houses curved around one side of a park. The exteriors of the rows were integrated into a unified scheme with larger homes flanking the row on each side, bedecked with columns. Tontine Crescent was not only more monumental than anything proposed by Robert Mills, who Bulfinch mentored, it also predated Mills's row house developments in Philadelphia by nearly two decades.

One would think that Tontine Crescent would have set the fashion in Boston for years to come. However, the row houses failed to sell, and so the second phase of the development on the opposite side of the park was changed to large, partially detached homes, which were much more popular.⁵ The spectacular failure of Tontine Crescent's row homes bankrupted Bulfinch and became a cautionary tale to other developers. Soon after, Mount Vernon Street in Boston's prestigious Beacon Hill neighborhood was subdivided into lots as wide as 200 feet, intended for freestanding mansions.



By the mid-nineteenth century, what had been a colonial hamlet of wooden buildings, packs of wild boars, and filthy people in tricorne hats trudging

through mud-clogged streets was utterly transformed by industrialization and an explosion in population. Between 1830 and 1870, Boston's population quadrupled as immigrants from Europe streamed into the city to work at the shipping yards, in boat building, and in textile factories arising as part of the Industrial Revolution. Old colonial homes, mansions such as the Paul Revere House, and warehouses were subdivided into apartments. Along Broad Street, which today is on the edge of the Financial District, up to thirty-seven people crammed into small two- and three-story houses.⁶ Central Boston's twisted and tortuous streets contributed to the area becoming one of the most congested places on Earth by the late nineteenth century. The old urban fabric of colonial Boston was bursting at the seams, and its profligate use of land on a waterlogged peninsula became untenable.

With open lots becoming increasingly scarce, even the city's elite succumbed to more urban types of housing. The gardens and open spaces between the stately, detached houses on Beacon Hill were filled in with additional structures, a change lamented by most of the Boston establishment. An aged Charles Bulfinch, perhaps still feeling bitter about Tontine Crescent, decried that the noble mansions, "trees and all, are swept away" for cramped housing.⁷ The writer Ralph Waldo Emerson recalled his childhood playing in large gardens in what is today downtown Boston and taking his mother's cow to pasture along Beacon Street. As he watched the idyllic Boston of his youth get paved over, he moved to rural Concord in 1834 and became famous for his screeds against cities.⁸

Faced with this crowded and dirty environment, many wealthy Boston families—some of whom traced their lineage back to the original Puritan settlers—decided to flee their traditional enclaves in the West End and atop Beacon Hill in favor of rural retreats west of the city. This was made possible by the opening of the Boston and Worcester Railroad in 1834, which ran to the nearby town of Newton in just thirty-nine minutes.⁹ These families had coalesced into a ruling elite dubbed the Boston Brahmin, and their departure forced city leaders to pursue a more orderly approach for expanding the city.

Between 1804 and 1900, the land reclamation Boston undertook more than doubled the size of the city, from 783 acres to nearly 2,000. This greatly expanded the neck connecting the Shawmut Peninsula to the mainland and dramatically changed the city's shape, reducing the vast harbor around it

to the width of a narrow river.¹⁰ On top of the swamps that had formerly delineated the narrow neck, two showpiece neighborhoods were created to entice the Brahmin to stay in the city. The first, the South End, was filled with three- and four-story brick row homes starting in 1849. These structures are spartanly ornamented and are marked by their distinctive, bow-fronted bay windows. While these structures are relatively plain, they retreat in many places to create lush public spaces. Brick row homes swoop around the curving perimeter of Chester Square like an American version of the Royal Crescent in Bath. In smaller and more intimate spaces like Harriet Tubman Square and Childe Hassam Park, people relax on benches amidst the lush landscaping. Many of the South End parks are so well cared for that they feel more like the backyard of a fastidious master gardener than a public space.

Yet the South End was just a warm-up act for the neighborhood that would be built directly north of the neck in 1859: Back Bay. Unlike the radial streets of the South End, Back Bay is laid out in a regular grid with the main thoroughfare, Commonwealth Avenue, running through the middle. Nearly half of the land was set aside for parks and open space, and the state-appointed commissioners enacted restrictions on the height and design of buildings.¹¹ Whereas the South End was developed with speculative row houses, the lots of Back Bay were sold directly to end buyers at auction; many were developed individually as large mansions clad in brownstone, brick, and granite to house the city's wealthiest residents.¹²

Both the South End and Back Bay were created with a level of detail and planning that had yet to be seen in any other American city—these neighborhoods achieve a cohesion between buildings, parks, and streets that is still unmatched by any other neighborhood in the country. Commonwealth Avenue—lined by grand row houses and divided by a tree-lined central median studded with monuments—has an imperial grandeur reminiscent of a European capital. One would imagine that the beauty and elegance of these two neighborhoods would have become a template for the future growth of Boston.

However, this would not be the case. The city's residents had given up their gardens and wood houses reluctantly. Their burning desire for these traditional forms was never truly extinguished, but merely lay dormant for several generations. The technological advances of the turn of the twentieth

century would finally allow them to regain this ideal. The neighborhoods that would develop along streetcar lines in the latter half of the nineteenth century would be a distinctly new type of urban environment.



By the late nineteenth century, the Shawmut Peninsula had morphed from a rural village into a congested city center that four hundred thousand people commuted into every workday. Along the jam-packed streets, pedestrians and carriages competed with eight thousand trolleys. These privately owned, horse-drawn omnibuses were hailed like a cab, and each had entirely different routes, fares structures, and operating hours. In 1887, the twenty different streetcar operators serving Boston were consolidated into the West End Street Railway, which became the largest unified streetcar system in the world. They adopted innovations now essential to modern mass transit systems, such as standardized fares and color-coded routes. The company was also one of the first to power their streetcars with electricity from overhead wires instead of horses, creating a much faster and smoother ride. The West End Street Railway even played a major role in creating the first subway in the US in 1897, allowing trolleys to bypass the congested streets above via a mile-and-a-half-long tunnel under Boston Common.¹³

Suddenly the twisted, tortured streets of the central city were seamlessly and efficiently connected to the surrounding region. After leaving the central business district, the streetcars fanned out on Washington Street, Dudley Street, Blue Hill Avenue, and other main roads leading to the then-rural hamlets of Dorchester, Roxbury, and Brookline. As riders left the smoke and congestion of Boston and entered the parks, amusement parks, and other attractions strategically placed at the end of the lines, they would notice signs advertising new homes poking out of empty fields. A country estate was now not just for the leisure class. The streetcar allowed a clerk or skilled craftsperson to live in a bucolic environment while still being within commuting distance of their workplace.

Since the 1830s, streetcars had existed in many American cities in the form of horse-pulled omnibuses. These slow, plodding services merely extended the existing pattern of the city they served. In Philadelphia, as Penn's grid was expanded, developers replicated the patterns of the old walking city in the new areas developing on the fringe. The blocks were

divided into the same narrow lots, with large row houses on the main streets and narrower ones on alleys and side streets. In New York, the rigid grid created by the Commissioners' Plan was first developed with row houses, later replaced by tenements and towering apartment buildings. However, the much faster and smoother electric streetcars introduced in the 1890s—combined with other new transit services like interurban railways, elevated trains, and subways—greatly expanded how far a person could comfortably travel in an American city. This, along with the advent of the bungalow and the Progressive Era floor plan, resulted in a renaissance in urban housing. In early twentieth century New York, modern apartments were built along subway lines in Brooklyn, Queens, and the Bronx. In Chicago, three- and four-flats and large courtyard apartments replaced flimsy wood workers cottages. On the outskirts of Philadelphia and Baltimore, large day lighter row houses with porches and front lawns filled the countryside.

However, in no American city is the difference between pre- and post-electric streetcar neighborhoods so distinct as in Boston. The city did not simply create new housing types but developed entirely new neighborhoods as well. Part of this was due to the city not mandating a unified grid or exercising power over the layout of new streets early in its history as was done in New York and Philadelphia. Even Boston's two paradigms of urban design, Back Bay and the South End, have vastly different street arrangements that are largely disconnected from one another and awkwardly collide around Boylston Street. The lack of a single grid meant that new neighborhoods would not be prescribed to pre-plotted blocks and lots.¹⁴

In a process described by Sam Bass Warner Jr. in his seminal book *Streetcar Suburbs*, rail lines and utilities were built through fields and forests along existing country roads. Developers would purchase long, narrow tracts of land stemming off streetcar routes, ranging in size from eight to forty acres. They would then subdivide them with their own street network. The result is that in the outer neighborhoods of Boston, streets weave in and out of each other for no apparent reason and are sporadically connected by short bits of road, some of which terminate in a dead end (see image 19). A popular internet meme contrasts a map of the rigid grid of New York with the confused mess of streets in the former streetcar suburb

and current Boston neighborhood of Roxbury. Written on the New York map is, “Because we want you to know where you are and where you are going.” The map of Boston says, “Because fuck you.”

After the Civil War, horse-drawn streetcar service was still skeletal, slow, and expensive, and the initial wave of suburbanization was largely reserved for the wealthy. The long commutes to and from the central city were only practical for business owners and other well-off families who had control over their daily schedules. For these families, builders essentially recreated the lost houses of the Shawmut Peninsula in the new suburbs: large wood-sided, gable-roofed homes with porches wrapping around the exterior. Yet this country mansion aesthetic was a deliberate illusion. These suburban houses were not single-family homes but duplexes composed of two apartments stacked on top of each other. Great pains were taken to conceal this fact. Each unit had a separate entrance and entirely different circulation systems of staircases (see image 20). Inside, each was appointed with all the amenities necessary for an upper-class Boston family of the time. Instead of the grid-like layout of row homes, they had sprawling Victorian floor plans. Radiating off a central reception hall were multiple rooms for entertaining, including a parlor and a dining room, all adorned with carefully crafted fixtures carved from wood and marble.¹⁵

The biggest advantage of these suburban structures—which became known as townhomes, connoting their large size but urban characteristics—was the light. Whereas row houses, due to their long and narrow lots, were 25 feet at their widest—and as small as 13 feet for tiny alley trinities—the townhomes were on lots 40 to 50 feet wide. This meant they did not have party walls like row houses, and windows could be placed on all four sides, bathing each unit in light.

The spacious, light-filled homes of the streetcar suburbs led to the row house falling out of fashion in Boston. In Back Bay, large apartment buildings whose units, like those in the streetcar suburbs, offered more dynamic layouts with light on all four sides became preferred over single-family row homes. By 1884, the city had over two thousand elevators in a variety of buildings.¹⁶ This “flat fever” corresponded with a rapid decline of the South End and its narrow brick row homes. The abrupt change in the neighborhood is encapsulated by the story of a wealthy merchant who, after seeing a man in shirtsleeves lounging on a neighboring stoop, exclaimed,

“Thunderation!” and hired movers the very next day.¹⁷ The South End was soon a teeming immigrant slum, with its once-stately row houses divided into tenements.



Due to the robust expansion of Boston’s transit system, by the turn of the twentieth century the streetcar went from serving the affluent to all classes of the city. Track mileage increased from 260 miles in 1891 to 408 in 1901, and ridership increased by more than one hundred million passengers a year. This enhanced mobility allowed even working-class residents to leave the slums of the central city and move to the suburbs, with the average length of a commute increasing from 7.5 miles in 1891 to 11.23 miles twenty years later.¹⁸ Crosstown lines in particular allowed lower-class laborers to get to various worksites across the region, as opposed to having to go into the central city and then transfer.¹⁹

Developers who had bought parcels after the Civil War had originally divided their lots to be as wide as 90 feet, anticipating wealthy residents seeking large single-family houses.²⁰ Sensing an opportunity to cater to a new demographic, these developers now subdivided the large lots into narrower plots ranging from 40 feet to 27 feet wide on which to build smaller and less expensive housing (see image 19). To make these smaller lots economically viable, the townhouse form was compressed to fit the long, narrow lots, and an extra floor was added to accommodate a third unit, turning the building from a duplex into a triplex. Instead of each unit having entirely separate entrances and staircases, one was built to serve all three units (see image 20).

While this building type was much denser and more modest than a townhome, its structure retained some of the building’s architectural features. Set back from the street with landscaped yards along the front, side, and back, it rose three stories from a rough stone foundation made from granite quarried in nearby Quincy. Due to their distance from the inner core of the city, instead of being clad in the brick mandated by the central city’s fire zone, they were clad in a tongue-and-groove wood sheathing. Like the townhomes and large Victorian houses, the exterior featured a bay window and large 12-foot-wide porch with the supports turned into a decorative feature, such as neoclassical columns.

The overall visual effect of these new buildings was slightly disconcerting. While the townhouses gave the impression of an elegant single-family house, the bizarre dimensions of these tall, narrow structures made them a conspicuous new presence. On some blocks they were packed cheek by jowl, with only a few feet separating each. They were dubbed *three-deckers* or *triple-deckers*, after an enormous multitiered British warship that itself was nicknamed “the sovereign of the seas.”²¹ In a 1961 article, the MIT professor Lloyd Rodwin said that few other urban housing types “flaunted their sheer ugliness more brazenly.”²²

However, the triple-decker retained the townhouse’s most important feature: providing light on all four sides, with each unit occupying an entire floor. This made the structure one of the first types of mass-built, multiunit housing for the working classes that demonstrated the Progressive Era floor plan. The interior units are typically 1,500 square feet, with an elegant sitting area in the bay window, a dining room, and up to three bedrooms (see image 20). As if to confirm their superiority over the row house, the main room in many triple-deckers was larger than first floor of some narrow South End row houses. Many units also had better light, air circulation, and green space than the upper-class houses of Back Bay.

The large front decks, one for each apartment, were sometimes referred to as piazzas and acted as formal outdoor rooms where the residents could sit on warm summer nights in their Sunday best and observe the goings-on in the neighborhood. A back porch served a more workaday function for doing the wash and drying clothes and was usually made from plain unvarnished wood. There was also a back entrance leading to a common hallway that then branched off into entrances into each unit’s kitchen.

The spacious, light-filled units made the triple-decker some of the highest quality working-class housing in late-nineteenth-century America—especially when compared with the center city of Boston, which was becoming denser by the day. Once-grand row houses in the South End and Beacon Hill were turned into boarding houses, and New York–style tenements started to replace old colonial buildings. As late as 1929, only half of all dwellings in the North End had a toilet. This area, which had sprouted around the colonial remnant of the Paul Revere House, had a population density of 799 people per acre, rivaling the densest parts of Manhattan at the time.²³

Between 1870 and 1920, sixteen thousand triple-deckers were constructed in Boston and across New England. As in Philadelphia and New York, this work was not done by large entities but by nearly nine thousand small builders who would construct one to two houses at a time. Each builder specialized in a specific design and floor plan that they would replicate again and again. These designs were passed down and shared among builders and were heavily influenced by existing buildings, such as the townhouses of rural New England, from where many of the builders hailed.²⁴

The lack of a rigid city grid, as well as the broader lots, resulted in triple-deckers demonstrating a diversity that rivaled the row house—which can still be seen in Boston to this day. The Jones Hill section of Dorchester consists of handsome triple-deckers with neoclassical details and sweeping views of Boston Harbor. South Boston has many early versions of the buildings that lack ornamentation or porches and are often so close together that they appear to be row houses. Along commercial streets are mixed-use versions of the building with the bottom story of the bay windows having been converted into street-level retail spaces.

The triple-decker spread across New England, with unique variations found in mill towns and large cities like Worcester, Massachusetts; Woonsocket, Rhode Island; and Lewiston, Maine. Over 1,200 were built in the port town of New Bedford, Massachusetts. In Hartford, Connecticut, there is a unique type that combines two triple-deckers into one building, clad in brick. This creates a much more imposing version of the building, which is known locally as a Perfect Six.

The unique development pattern of the streetcar suburbs has given many of these residential neighborhoods a far different character than other large Northeastern cities. The winding tree-filled lanes in the city of Cambridge or in Boston's Jamaica Plain neighborhood could not be more different from the tightly packed brick-and-concrete blocks in Brooklyn or Philadelphia. Yet just as the suburban Boston townhouses have the external appearance of single-family houses but are actually duplexes, the suburban look of these triple-decker neighborhoods is also deceptive. The streetcar suburbs of Boston are some of the most walkable, densely populated, and transit accessible areas in the US. This is because these neighborhoods, even as they boasted more greenery and space than the urban core, still needed to be within walking distance of streetcar lines, businesses, and

services. In order to maximize space for development, the townhouses and triple-deckers often take up the entirety of their lots, leaving only a setback of a few feet on each side. The greenery surrounding the structures is more of a buffer than a usable yard. Many neighborhoods where townhouses and triple-deckers dominate have a population density comparable to the row houses of Back Bay and the South End.



While much of Boston may have had a greener and more open atmosphere than New York, the two shared one key similarity: both were cities of renters. Even though the triple-deckers and townhouses looked like single family homes, they were still apartments, and the abundance of multiunit buildings meant that savings and loans never gained a foothold as they did in Philadelphia or Baltimore. In Massachusetts, such institutions were called cooperative banks and were promoted by legislation passed by Josiah Quincy in 1877. Quincy wanted the middle-class of Boston to be “a house owning people instead of a house renting people.” Yet after a small surge in cooperative banks following this legislation, by 1890 only 2 percent of all families in Boston had used one.²⁵

For most working- and lower-class Bostonians, the price of a single-family house was too high, even with the assistance of a lending society. Developers found that the demand was for two- and three-unit buildings. With stand-alone houses out of reach, many working-class Bostonians would scrape together a down payment for a triple-decker. The owner would then usually move into the second-story unit, considered the most pleasant because it did not get as hot as the first floor, which was next to the basement broiler, or as cold as the top floor, where heat escaped into the uninsulated attic. The other two units would be rented out to relatives, which would help subsidize the owner’s mortgage payments. The new, expensive utilities of the Progressive Era plan were also made more affordable by splitting the cost among the units.²⁶

Through this, the three-decker itself became what the savings and loan was in other cities: an engine of mobility that allowed immigrants to leave the crowded slums of central Boston and ascend to the middle class. A study of the city’s streetcar suburbs done shortly before World War I estimated that up to 50 percent of the small dwellings and three-unit

buildings in those areas were owned by immigrants. Sociologists at the time called the streetcar suburbs “zones of emergence” because they allowed immigrants to assimilate into American society. Through homeownership, residents became more engaged in the broader affairs of their communities, gaining an interest in “government, neighborhood, and the greater community situation.”²⁷

The structure of the triple-decker also ingrained itself into the life of the community. The front deck of each unit took on almost ceremonial quality and was used when esteemed guests arrived for dinner and for communions, holidays, weddings, and funerals. Young people would have dates there with older relatives sitting nearby in the front parlor, keeping a watchful eye. As the professor Kingston Heath described, the porch symbolized “private ownership, civility and taste”; it was a mark that the building was not a tenement but a socially acceptable structure.²⁸ This social aspect of the triple-decker also fostered tightly knit communities where neighbors knew and cared for one another. During the 1912 Bread and Roses Strike in Lawrence, Massachusetts, mill workers organized using existing networks of neighbors within the city’s triple-decker apartment buildings.

Through this, the triple-decker has gained a kind of mystique as the incubator of New England’s immigrant culture. Structures that once housed Irish, Jews, and Italians are now home to Vietnamese in Dorchester, Cape Verdeans in Roxbury, Puerto Ricans and Dominicans in Lawrence, and Somalis in Lewiston. It has also become synonymous with Boston’s blue-collar identity and is often highlighted in the many films shot in the region. In *Good Will Hunting* (1997), Matt Damon, playing the titular genius janitor employed at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, is shown poring over books in his nearly empty three-decker apartment, a bare light bulb illuminating the alcove of a bay window. His best friend, played by Ben Affleck, visits him via the back porch. In countless other films from *Mystic River* (2003) to *Spenser Confidential* (2020), the building serves as a visual shorthand for working-class authenticity.



As Boston grew into an industrial metropolis in the nineteenth century, the Brahmin elite consolidated their position on Mount Vernon Street in Beacon Hill. The city below had changed dramatically around them.

The gardens of stately homes had been replaced by row houses, and the old colonial districts of the North and West Ends had been filled with towering five- and six-story brick tenements and boarding houses. These slum apartments were climbing up the northern slope of Beacon Hill like intruders scaling a castle wall.

The tenements and boarding houses signified a broader demographic change. By 1910, Boston was no longer a Puritan village but a melting pot, with 74 percent of the population composed of either immigrants or their children. Before 1882, 85 percent of immigrants coming into the US had been from Northern Europe. However, by the turn of the twentieth century, worsening poverty and anti-Semitic pogroms in Europe, along with increased ship travel, led a much more diverse array of people to seek refuge in America. The total number of immigrants also increased dramatically: Between 1900 and 1910, 7.6 million immigrants entered the country, compared to fewer than 4 million in the previous decade.

Since the mid-1800s, Boston had taken in large numbers of Irish who, by the turn of the twentieth century, had reshaped the city and ascended politically. While the Brahmins did not particularly care for them, they shared a history going back to the British Isles, as well as a language. In contrast, the Brahmins found the new wave of immigrants hailing from Southern and Eastern Europe utterly incomprehensible. In 1907, Henry Adams, the descendant of two presidents and Brahmin royalty, published his acclaimed autobiography. In it, he described a Jewish immigrant he had encountered on the streets of central Boston as “still reeking of the ghetto, snarling a weird Yiddish.”²⁹

As the writer Daniel Okrent describes in his book *The Guarded Gate*, by the turn of the twentieth century, the red-brick row houses of Mount Vernon Street had become the center of the nation’s anti-immigrant movement. Joe Lee, one of Boston’s most prominent citizens, founded an organization called the Immigration Restriction League. Meanwhile, Massachusetts senator and Brahmin Henry Cabot Lodge worked in Washington to establish regulations like required literacy tests aimed at barring immigrants from Southern and Eastern Europe.

The elite of America, many of whom had descended from the original colonists, saw the new immigrants from Southern and Eastern Europe as genetically inferior and a threat to the country’s future. As Senator Lodge

repeatedly said in the 1890s, “We must guard our civilization against an infusion which seems to threaten deterioration.”³⁰ The fervor against immigrants was also undeniably linked to the conditions of the slums in which they lived, as well as to the proximity of the elite to these slums, especially in the large cities of the Northeast. Francis Amasa Walker, the first president of MIT, wrote an article in the *Yale Review* advocating for a large entry fee to be placed on immigrants, citing the photographs of Jacob Riis to say that they “lived like swine.” The Immigration Restriction League argued over whether it would be wise to relocate immigrants to farms, with many countering that this would just create more room in the slums that would in turn attract more immigrants. Madison Grant, one of the founders of the Bronx Zoo, said that the swamps of Jewish Poland were being drained into the Lower East Side, which was also “a dumping ground of Italians.”³¹

The type of dense housing found in the urban neighborhoods of large US cities—already considered anathema to the American way of life—became a proxy for immigrants. A 1917 article about the “three decker menace” in *Providence Magazine* said that “the recent immigrants from Southeastern Europe have not the home-owning instinct of the earlier races, although sometimes very keen to exploit the benefits of jerry building. Assuming, therefore, that vertical housing is with us for a longtime to come.”³² The Brahmins and other anti-immigration elites found surprising allies in Progressive reformers, who often came from the same Protestant background and shared similar prejudices. Reformer Lawrence Veiller, champion of New York State’s 1901 Tenement House Act and secretary of the Tenement House Committee there, spent his later years advocating for the sterilization of disabled people.³³ Jacob Riis, when not describing slum conditions in his 1890 book *How the Other Half Lives*, shared his thoughts on the inhabitants of these buildings, describing the Jews as worshiping money, the Italians as childlike criminals, and the Chinese as godless.³⁴

The triple-decker—set back from the street and often nestled in greenery with spacious, modern floor plans—was far from being a tenement. The widespread adoption of the building was even partially due to housing reform laws. A law passed in 1897 by the City of Boston, which required that all tenements be fully fireproof, was amended in 1900 to allow an exception for buildings of fewer than four stories in height, with two

or fewer apartments above the second floor.³⁵ This provision essentially sanctioned the triple-decker, prompting developers to pivot to constructing the building type en masse in the streetcar suburbs: whereas in 1899, buildings with three units comprised only 12 percent of all new buildings built in the city, by 1915 almost half of all new buildings built in Boston were triple-deckers.³⁶

This tenement law also shifted the demographics of many streetcar suburbs. By the early twentieth century, immigrants and African American migrants began to bypass crowded central districts like the North, West, and South Ends and moved directly to outer neighborhoods like Roxbury and Dorchester. As Jews, Italians, and African Americans moved into these formerly low-density areas—now made high-density by the triple-decker—these neighborhoods came to be regarded as extensions of central Boston slums. The new immigrants were poorer than the former residents of these neighborhoods, and many of the buildings in which they lived were owned or managed by absentee landlords who allowed them to fall into disrepair. In some cases units within the buildings were subdivided and the landscaping was paved over with concrete, where litter collected over time. However, for the most part, the triple-deckers remained a middle-class structure; whereas the rent for a unit in a central city tenement was between twelve to fourteen dollars a month in the 1920s, a unit in a triple-decker was between fourteen and thirty-five dollars a month.³⁷ In 1900, the average death rate in the triple-decker-filled streetcar suburb of Dorchester was one in seventy-two, compared to one in forty-eight for the entire city and one in thirty-nine in the North End.³⁸

Yet to “native Americans,” as longtime New Englanders referred to themselves, the triple-deckers and their foreign inhabitants were regarded as being little better than a tenement, and the structure was referred to as a “cracker box” and “Boston weed.”³⁹ The Great Chelsea Fire of 1908 gave additional justification for banning the wooden building type: 350 acres burned in a dense city full of triple-deckers just north of Boston, leaving tens of thousands of people homeless. This tragedy, combined with a similar fire several years later in Salem, Massachusetts, caused the triple-decker to be regarded not only as an eyesore but also as physically dangerous. However, such beliefs overlooked the fact that the Chelsea fire was not started by a triple-decker resident overcooking their lasagna, but

rather by a rag dump in a nearby industrial area. A contemporary report of the fire said the heat was so hot that “buildings made of solid granite crumbled.”⁴⁰ If the triple-decker was a safety threat, then so too were the city hall, library, multiple churches, synagogues, and other structures that had also succumbed to the blaze.⁴¹

The Great Chelsea Fire unleashed a rash of increasingly draconian local laws aimed at curbing the triple-decker. Whereas the laws regulating the tenement in New York at the time were based in actual issues relating to health and safety, the laws aimed at triple-deckers were primarily an attempt to ban immigrants from living in certain neighborhoods. By 1912, urban reformers had succeeded in advancing the Tenement House Act for Towns through the Massachusetts State House. This law enabled municipalities to ban new wooden apartment buildings that allowed cooking above the second floor.⁴² In the wealthy suburb of Brookline, where many Brahmins had summer homes, triple-deckers were banned on the grounds that they caused “juvenile delinquency,” which at the time was a dog whistle for immigrants and people of color.⁴³

Five years after the passage of the Tenement House Act for Towns, William C. Ewing, a Brahmin member of the Boston Planning Board as well as a member of the board of directors on the Boston Chamber of Commerce, wrote a letter to the nearby small city of Taunton, which was considering a similar measure. After describing the benefits of triple-deckers over brick apartments, attributable to their spacious light-filled units, Ewing declared that the structure was nevertheless deleterious because it was inhabited by renters. In a sentence that ties the knot between Brahmin eugenicists and housing reformers, he concluded by saying that “the ideal dwelling for the normal family is the detached single-family home.”⁴⁴

In 1927, the construction of new triple-deckers was effectively prohibited in Boston with the adoption of a new city zoning code.⁴⁵ New buildings were now required to have ample setbacks and to use expensive construction techniques. The accumulation of these regulations made the triple-decker impossible to build.⁴⁶ The Boston code was joined by similar laws passed around the country banning a range of urban housing, from the row house to other types of small apartment buildings.

By this point such bans were a mere formality. Three years prior to the passage of the new Boston building code, the anti-immigration measures

of the federal Johnson-Reed Act had effectively cut off much of the new demand for such buildings. This act capped total immigration into the country at 155,000 per year and drastically limited immigration from all places other than Northern Europe. Italians were limited to 2,662 people per year, and the countries of what would later become the Soviet Bloc, including Russia and Poland, were limited to 7,346. Areas that had very little representation in the US in 1890, including Greece and all of Asia, were capped at 100 per year. Without the wave of immigrants to live in triple-deckers, there was no reason for developers to build them.⁴⁷



A trip down Blue Hill Avenue through the southern Boston neighborhoods of Dorchester and Roxbury reveals an astounding variety of housing types. Triple-deckers, bow-fronted brick row houses, large apartment buildings with stores at the bottom, small pitched-roof houses that look like they could be from a New England fishing village, and townhouse duplexes all sit side by side. The mixture of housing found along Blue Hill Avenue and throughout Boston reflects the liberty that was granted to the city's early builders. Because they could arrange tracts how they saw fit, they were able to adapt their buildings to meet demographic trends and market conditions. Freed from the long skinny lots that had bedeviled developers in New York and Philadelphia, they used the extra space to create new configurations for urban housing that allowed for more greenery and open, light-filled apartments.

Today this sort of innovation in urban housing is rare. The xenophobic laws that banned buildings like the triple-decker in the 1920s have since been tightened with additional restrictions. Many areas where triple-deckers predominate, both in Boston and in outlying cities like Somerville, have been downzoned to only allow two units of housing. In most Boston neighborhoods, each apartment is required to provide at least one parking space, which is nearly impossible on a small urban lot.

However, the qualities that made the triple-decker livable and desirable one hundred years ago have endured to this day: their light-filled and spacious units, broad porches, and locations in quiet residential neighborhoods that are close to transit and amenities. The buildings along Blue Hill Avenue represent a type of housing that has become increasingly prized

in planning and policy circles, dubbed *missing middle housing*. This term, coined by Berkeley architect Daniel Parolek in 2010, describes buildings that have the qualities of a single-family home in terms of scale and materials but that contain three to six housing units. Like the townhouses first built in Boston's streetcar suburbs, missing middle housing is designed to be unobtrusive and sometimes indistinguishable from a single-family house when seen from the street.

Today a new movement is underway to once again create missing middle housing types like the triple-decker. Planners and designers see this as a solution to the nation's housing crisis because these structures gently add density to single-family neighborhoods without disrupting their overall physical character. Since missing middle housing provides multiple units on the same size lot as a single-family home would, it is also inherently more affordable, and because they are often composed of rental units, they allow people who would not otherwise be able to purchase a home in a certain neighborhood to still live there.

A bird's-eye view of Boston shows the skyscrapers and huddled-together red-brick structures of the Shawmut Peninsula and surrounding districts. Yet a few miles away, this cluster dissipates into small wood buildings nestled in a sea of trees. Structures like the triple-decker are examples of how the streetcar of the late 1800s freed urban housing from tiny lots, dark and narrow row houses, and claustrophobic tenements. From the Cleveland Double and colonnade apartment buildings of Kansas City to the bungalow courts of the West Coast, countless options became available in terms of how to organize space. These structures blurred the lines between suburb and city, house and apartment, and owner and renter. Yet as the triple-decker shows, even these innovative multifamily buildings became tinged with anti-poor and anti-immigrant biases that no amount of space, amenities, or sunlight could surmount.